

August

7

High wire walk

1974

To the astonishment of people watching 400 m (1,312 ft) below, French tightrope artist Philippe Petit walked on a wire strung between the tops of the towers of the World Trade Center in New York City, USA.

Also on this day

1819 Venezuelan general **Simón Bolívar** defeated Spanish forces at the Battle of Boyacá, which helped free Venezuela and Colombia from Spanish rule.

1987 US swimmer **Lynne Cox** became the first person to swim between the USA and the Soviet Union.

1996 After studying a Martian meteorite that landed in Antarctica, scientists announced they had found strong evidence that simple life forms may have existed on Mars more than 3.6 billion years ago.



1942

Talking in code

During World War II, a US marine unit with 15 Navajo code talkers landed on the Pacific island of Guadalcanal to help fight against Japan. The code talkers used the Navajo language to encode US military messages, as Japanese forces could not understand it.

1948

Historic jump

US athlete Alice Coachman became the first Black woman to win an Olympic gold medal with her victory in the high jump event at the London Olympic Games. Her 1.68 m (5.6 ft) leap set a world record at the time.



Born this day

1975 **Charlize Theron**, South African-American actor and producer. She won an Academy Award for Best Actress for her work.